else. It does not matter so long as you think that the goal is one. That is the basis of Indian tolerance, that is the reason why we welcome Parsis and other oppressed people when they came to this country … So long as Indian culture, which is essentially vedic Hindu culture, survives in India there is nothing to fear for Muslims, Christians and others. They will live with us as equal citizens. But if that culture is not there, I do not know what will happen. Therefore, roots of secularism, roots of tolerance, in India are not Gandhi or Nehru or Congress or this or that party. The roots lie in Indian culture and philosophy as set out in the Vedas.'[136]

The Jan Sangh's Holy Cow

The cow first appeared on the Jan Sangh manifesto in 1962, when it declared: 'The Bharatiya Jana Sangh will amend the Constitution to prohibit the slaughter of the bovine species and enact necessary legislation.'[137] The party also promised to establish dairies, goshalas and gosadans. From the beginning, the Jan Sangh saw the cow as absolutely essential for the Indian economy. As its party president declared in 1966, 'In our ancient literature three things have been described as mother. First, is the real mother. Second is the motherland. Third is the cow. Cow and bull have been the mainstay of our economy. I may tell you that cow is the only animal which approximates in many ways to the human body. Firstly, cow gives birth after nine months. Cow's milk is the nearest approximation to that of mother's milk. Therefore, cow has rightly occupied a special place in the Indian economy and sentiment.'[138]

The Jan Sangh argued that men do not live on bread alone, but by sentiment. 'Cow is a question of sentiments for millions of our people. If we are a democracy, as we profess to be, then we must pay attention to the sentiments and emotions of the large majority of our people. If we do not do that, then we are not democratic.'[139] In fact, the Government of India appointed a committee in 1952. The committee was clear on the point that even today, 'cow can be an asset to our economy. Of course, there are many cows which are useless and they should be sterilised. So from the economic point of view also cow will be an asset and not a liability. Therefore ban on